

Step One

We admitted we were powerless over alcohol, that our lives had become unmanageable.

Step One is and continues to become the foundation of our recovery. In the Dr's Opinion and the first three chapters of *Alcoholics Anonymous*, the exact nature of our problem and malady is laid out for us through the idea that we suffer from a twofold illness involving a physical allergy and mental obsession to alcohol. The physical allergy is characterized by craving once the drug is introduced into our body. This craving ensures that our ability to control the amount we ingest becomes increasingly difficult to predict or manage. Invariably we end up drinking or using more than intended and undesirable consequences occur.

The second part of our illness is the obsession of the mind. The obsession in every alcoholic has unique manifestations but ultimately creates the illusion that next use will be different, meaning without negative consequences through an ability to control or manage the amount. In the face of mounting evidence to the contrary, we continue to fall prey to the allure that next time can be different for us. This becomes the cunning, powerful, and baffling nature of our disease. Knowing and understanding the problem is essential as correct understanding of my problem helps define the solution I am in need of. It is here we learn that we suffer from a body that cannot tolerate what our mind can't leave alone. It is in the honesty with which we approach recovery that allows us to learn the truth about the problem.

Suggested readings:

Dr's Opinion XXV-XXXII, **Alcoholics Anonymous**

Bill's Story, **Alcoholics Anonymous**

More About Alcoholism, **Alcoholics Anonymous**

Step 1, **Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions**

Step Two

Came to believe that a Power greater than ourselves could restore us to sanity.

Having learned the truth and nature of our problem in Step One, and seeing that life is/was becoming intolerable, it is increasingly clear that these are old ideas and our self-reliance was a liability in the face of this dilemma. Sequentially, Step One is the foundation of our recovery and having seen how our attempt at self-management has failed us we face the prospect of developing a relationship through a willingness on our part to believe there may be something that can begin a healing process. Step Two presents us with the “God idea”. Now we examine our idea of that idea. Step Two is the cornerstone placed on the foundation of our journey.

Suggested readings:

Ch. 2 There is a Solution, **Alcoholics Anonymous**

Ch. 3 More About Alcoholism, **Alcoholics Anonymous**

Ch. 4 We Agnostics, **Alcoholics Anonymous**

Step Two, **Twelve Steps Twelve Traditions**

Step Three

Made a decision to turn our will and our lives over to the care of God as we understood Him.

In the basic text, *Alcoholics Anonymous*, we are told on page 62 that Step Three is the keystone of the new and triumphant arch through which we passed to freedom. The book also shares three pertinent ideas on page 60 which must be confronted and answered honestly by each individual if they are to be successful in their journey. The ideas are referred to as the ABC's of recovery and they are as follows:

[a] That we were alcoholic and could not manage our own lives. Step One

[b] That probably no human power could have relieved our alcoholism. Step Two

[c] That God could and would if He were sought. Step Two

Based on our decision in regard to these three ideas, we are confronted by the problem of our historical over reliance on self and high resolve. We are also faced with a decision and a call for action.

Suggested readings:

Ch. 1 Bill's Story, **Alcoholics Anonymous**

Ch. 2 There Is a Solution, **Alcoholics Anonymous**

Ch. 5 How It Works, **Alcoholics Anonymous**

Step Three, **Twelve Steps Twelve Traditions**

Step Four

Made a searching and fearless moral inventory of ourselves.

In Step Four, we are given the direction to begin an inventory that focuses on three aspects of our lives, resentments, fears and sexual behavior. The first three steps have prepared us for this challenge provided we have been honest with ourselves. We are asked to inventory the truth about our stock in trade because in so doing we clearly see the things in us that are in need of transformation. In the absence of these matters being transformed, we will only continue to transfer them often to the people closest to us and with damaging effects. Looking at the steps as a sequential experience, the truth of my Step One creates a necessity in our willingness to believe in a power greater, Step Two, which prompts me to arrive at a decision in Step Three. A decision for what? To take action by putting pen to paper as outlined in step 4. Our willingness to do these things being indispensable.

Suggested readings:

Chapter 5, How It Works, **Alcoholics Anonymous**

Step Four, **Twelve Steps Twelve Traditions**

Step Five

Admitted to God, ourselves, and another human being the exact nature of our wrongs

Step Five for many of us raises the question of why must I share what I found in my written 4th step with another human being? On page 72 of the basic text we are given the answer that usually we find a solitary self-appraisal insufficient. This may be an oversimplification. There are many benefits to this process and if we can put our fear aside and move forward with sharing our work with another person, we become open to experiencing the truth on a greater level and meaningful connection with self, others and a God of our understanding.

Suggested reading:

Chapter 6 Into Action, **Alcoholics Anonymous**

Step Five, **Twelve Steps Twelve Traditions**

Step Six

Were entirely ready to have God remove all these defects of character

It is interesting to note that the basic text of Alcoholics Anonymous says the least about this step than any of the other steps. Defects or shortcomings, whatever you prefer to call them, create lower self actions which our 4th step inventory uncovered. In the paragraph devoted to this step, it is clear the importance of willingness on our part to relinquish these things to a Power greater than ourselves if we are to experience meaningful healing in our lives. Remember what we are in need of healing will either be transformed or it will continue to be transferred.

Suggested reading:

Page 76, **Alcoholics Anonymous**

Step Six, **Twelve Steps Twelve Traditions**

Step Seven

Humbly asked Him to remove our shortcomings

My Creator, I am now willing that you should have all of me, good and bad. I pray that you now remove from me every single defect of character which stands in the way of my usefulness to you and my fellows. Grant me strength as I go out from here, to do your bidding. Amen

Suggested reading:

Page 76 Seventh Step Prayer, **Alcoholics Anonymous**

Step Eight

Made a list of all the people we had harmed, and became willing to make amends to them all.

In continuing in the process of transformation which began in Step One, we continue on this journey through the actions we are taking in Steps Four through Nine. If we have done a thorough 4th step, making our list in Step Eight becomes easier. We go back and see the people we have held resentments against as well as those that have been harmed by our sexual conduct will be on this list. We have also learned in this process that although many of them did in fact harm us too, we are only focused on the harms we have done them.

Step Nine

Made direct amends to such people wherever possible, except when to do so would injure them or others

On some matters, taking this step alone at the very least can be damaging and ill advised. We review our amends with our sponsor being clear on the exact nature of our wrongs as this understanding defines the nature of the amend.

Suggested readings:

Chapter 6 Into Action, **Alcoholics Anonymous**

Step Eight, **Twelve Steps Twelve Traditions**

Step Nine, **Twelve Steps Twelve Traditions**

Step Ten

Continued to take personal inventory and when wrong promptly admitted it

At Step Ten, we return to the inventory process we first encountered in Step Four. This becomes our spiritual practice and our spiritual way of living. What we uncover in our daily Step Ten connects us to Step Six shortcomings which harm and injure other people. We are directed to watch for selfishness, dishonesty, resentment and fear which are the subsequent emotional states of unbridled shortcomings left unchecked.

Step 11

Sought through prayer and meditation to improve our conscious contact with God as we understood Him, praying only for knowledge of His will and the power to carry that out

The Big Book shares with us that we will enter a 4th dimension of existence of which we had not ever dreamed. On page 25 and then on page 85, it suggests we have begun to develop a vital sixth sense. The 4th dimension refers to the world of the spirit and the 6th sense is the result of connection to higher consciousness resulting in greater intuition or intuitive nudges when faced with moments of indecision.

Suggested readings:

Step 10, **Twelve Steps Twelve Traditions**

Chapter 6, Into Action, **Alcoholics Anonymous**

Step 11, **Twelve Steps Twelve Traditions**

Step 12

Having had a spiritual awakening as a result of these steps, we tried to carry this message to other alcoholics, and to practice these principles in all our affairs

At this point in our journey of recovery from the malady of our alcoholism, we have undergone a miraculous change of heart. We achieved this by following the directions contained in the sequence of the Steps. We have undertaken a course which demands rigorous honesty on our part. We have given ourselves to principles that are spiritual in nature. Step 12 calls us to service in working with others showing them the steps we have taken as we continue to grow through the practice of these principles in all our affairs.

Suggested readings:

Chapter 7, Working with Others, **Alcoholics Anonymous**

Step 12, **Twelve Steps Twelve Traditions**

Chapter 11, A Vision for You, **Alcoholics Anonymous**

